

The Complexity of Multilateral Negotiations: Problem or Opportunity? A Qualitative Study of Five Simulations with Mexican Students

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Abstract: Education in International Relations requires continual evolution. One approach is the use of negotiation simulations for complex issues. Despite the extensive literature on the subject, there is a lack of qualitative research on this approach, particularly in Latin America and Mexico. This paper presents the findings of a qualitative research on five simulations with Mexican students. The five exercises were characterized by the application of elements that are not usually included in traditional simulations, such as a multiweek phase of prior negotiations, the use of Twitter, the introduction of nonstate actors, a gala dinner, and a continuous feed of real world news. We investigated 118 participants through 30 in depth interviews analyzed with *NVivo*, a systematized analysis of 118 reports, documents and tweets, and a pre-post questionnaire applied to the fifth group. The results in the five simulations were highly positive. The students reported a greater awareness of the complexity of international negotiations. Such awareness can present both a risk and an opportunity: a risk because those circumstances caused discouragement and frustration in many participants, and an opportunity because those same circumstances, properly channeled, triggered parallel skills, and creative thinking. Therefore, the role of the facilitation team was fundamental.

Resumen: Las simulaciones de negociación son útiles para enseñar sobre temas complejos. Sin embargo, a pesar de la abundante literatura sobre el tema, hay una falta de investigación cualitativa sobre estas simulaciones, particularmente en el contexto de América Latina y México. En este artículo, se presentan los resultados de una investigación cualitativa sobre cinco simulaciones con estudiantes mexicanos. Los cinco ejercicios incluyeron elementos que generalmente no se encuentran en las simulaciones, que incluyen una fase de varias semanas previa a las negociaciones, el uso de Twitter, la introducción de actores no estatales, una cena de gala y una fuente continua de noticias del mundo real. Investigamos a 118 participantes a través de 30 entrevistas en profundidad analizadas con *NVivo*, realizamos un análisis sistematizado de 118 informes, documentos y tuits de estudiantes, y utilizamos un cuestionario previo y posterior con un grupo de control a los efectos del contraste. Los estudiantes informaron una mayor conciencia acerca de la complejidad de las negociaciones internacionales, una conciencia que presenta tanto el riesgo de desmotivación y frustración en algunos participantes como la oportunidad de motivar el pensamiento creativo de los estudiantes. Concluimos que la gestión de los riesgos y las oportunidades requiere de un equipo de facilitación comprometido.

Extrait: Les simulations de négociation sont utiles pour amener des enseignements concernant des problèmes complexes. Cependant, malgré

la littérature abondante sur le sujet, les recherches qualitatives sur ces simulations manquent, en particulier dans le contexte de l'Amérique latine et du Mexique. Cet article présente les résultats d'une recherche qualitative sur cinq simulations avec des étudiants mexicains. Les cinq exercices comprenaient des éléments que l'on ne trouve généralement pas dans les simulations, notamment une phase de négociations préalables de plusieurs semaines, l'utilisation de Twitter, l'introduction d'acteurs non étatiques, un dîner de gala et un flux continu d'actualités du monde réel. Nous avons enquêté sur 118 participants dans le cadre de 30 entretiens approfondis analysés avec *NVivo*, mené une analyse systématisée de 118 rapports d'étudiants, documents et tweets et utilisé un questionnaire avant-après avec un groupe de contrôle aux fins de contraste. Les étudiants ont signalé une prise de conscience accrue de la complexité des négociations internationales—une prise de conscience qui présente à la fois un risque de découragement et de frustration chez certains participants, ainsi qu'une opportunité de déclencher une réflexion créative de la part des étudiants. Nous concluons que la gestion des risques et des opportunités nécessite une équipe de facilitation engagée.

Keywords: simulations, negotiations, education, didactic tools, Models UN, MUN, MUNs

Education in international relations requires continual evolution. One approach is the use of negotiation simulations for complex issues. Despite the extensive literature on the subject, there is a lack of qualitative research on this approach, particularly in Latin America and Mexico. This paper presents the findings of a qualitative research on five simulations with Mexican students. The five exercises were characterized by the application of elements that are not usually included in traditional simulations, such as a multiweek phase of prior negotiations, the use of Twitter and other digital tools, the introduction of nonstate actors, a gala dinner, and a continuous feed of real-world news. This research team used a set of different techniques to identify a methodological triangulation that would provide better substantiated results. These questions guided our research: In the students' assessments, what types of benefits do they derive from negotiation simulations? What types of disadvantages or risks do these students perceive resulting from these simulations? What topics stand out most in the students' conversations and memories of the simulations later on in their studies? Lastly, is it possible to understand student perceptions by contrasting them with the observation and analysis of objective elements such as social media activity during the simulations or other documentation produced before, during, and after the simulations?

In essence, the topics that we sought to explore were as follows. Did the simulations benefit students' negotiation skills? Did the simulations help the students with the conceptual assimilation of the course content on international negotiations? Did the simulations help students understand the complexity of international negotiations, and did the simulations improve other skills such as socializing and public speaking? We also sought to explore the effect these simulations had on the students' level of interest and enthusiasm about the negotiation topics or their research skills. In addition, we sought to understand which simulation experiences presented difficulties or were otherwise assessed negatively by the students.

In view of this study, we can affirm that it is not only possible but necessary to apply alternative educational tools that trigger creativity, imagination, and parallel thinking in students and that doing so does not need to be a tedious process. The world requires different ideas and different ways of conceiving, understanding, and proposing. The objective of this paper is to provide some elements that may contribute to this end.

The paper first includes a brief review of the subject-matter literature and an identification of the gaps in that literature, specifically in Latin America and Mexico. Subsequently, we present the methodology used and the results obtained. The remainder of the paper includes a discussion of the results and recommendations both for future research and for professors interested in these types of educational strategies.

Background and Conceptual Framework

The literature exploring the use of simulations and negotiation models is vast. Some texts discuss the use of simulations as analytical or scientific tools, while others discuss the use of simulations as an educational method. Brynen and Milante (2012, 29) argue that, although the main value of negotiation simulations is pedagogical and encourages practice, these simulations are inevitably built on an explicit or implicit model of reality and that this construct is essentially an exercise in social science theorization. As a consequence, simulations can be used as research tools to examine the implications of hypothetical relationships and the dynamics of conflicts. For example, researchers and experts from Israel's Institute for National Security Studies recently conducted a simulation to examine the dynamics and reactions from all actors involved if the United States were to withdraw from the nuclear agreement it signed with Iran in 2015 (which had not occurred at the time of that simulation; Shine 2018, 2–3). The advantage they found in carrying out such a simulation, in contrast to a debate or traditional situational analyses, was the ability to personally observe a series of plausible interactions between the different actors. Shine admits that the results may not be completely realistic but proposes that these exercises can shed light on ideas and concepts that had not been considered by experts in the field.

Smith and Boyer (1996) argued two decades ago that simulations were consistently part of research and analysis, but they had not been used enough as teaching tools. In the view of these authors, simulations have the capacity to recreate difficult political processes to examine the motivations, behaviors, and interactions of the different actors. According to Stice (1987, cited in Smith and Boyer 1996, 690–691), participants in a simulation usually present a better understanding of the subject, and after the simulation exercise they can retain up to 90 percent of what they do and say in those exercises. Similarly, the student experiences many of the motivations and obstacles experienced by the real actors (Smith and Boyer 1996, 691). After Smith and Boyer, other authors began recommending simulations as educational tools. Despite this turn, Brynen and Milante (2012, 29) say that they understand the skepticism that simulations can evoke because social and political processes are complex; the specific dynamics of peace and conflict, for example, usually depend on context, which is something that is not always replicable in a classroom.

Asal and Kratoville (2013, 132–133) review the existing theories regarding the development and use of negotiation simulations and conclude that such exercises are designed to strike a balance between students' perceptions of past events and the theories that could explain those events. Applying a constructivist approach to pedagogy, the authors argue that, when a simulation is well designed, it has the potential to bring the participants closer to a realistic situation and allows them to apply theoretical knowledge to that reality. Furthermore, Brynen and Milante (2012, 29) argue that simulations and games in classrooms are important educational and practical tools for students to become future international negotiators. In their view, simulations serve as heuristic tools that enable novel and creative thinking about complex issues and aid in comparing worldviews to obtain a shared understanding of the great challenges faced by our societies.

What type of simulation or negotiation model works best? Brynen (2010), for example, details a negotiation simulation conducted over seven days in a group

that combined undergraduate, masters, and doctoral students at McGill University in Canada. The simulation described by the author involved an invented country and continent, but with real or plausible events. The simulation's seven days represented a month during which the actors were compelled to negotiate. Three types of actors were used in this simulation: diplomatic actors, military actors, and civil society actors (from the media to labor unions). The simulation was evaluated based on a nonsystemized review of essays written by the students. The students said that the simulation helped them to understand class topics and helped to improve their professional and personal negotiation skills. In addition, students were so involved with the subject that, years later, the students continued to have a Facebook group dedicated to the conflict, although it had occurred in an imaginary country. Two facets of Brynen's report were informative for our research: First, in Brynen's simulation—like other simulation reports—the overall evaluation was based only on the facilitator's observations and/or by reviewing tests or reports. Second, Brynen noted that simulations lasting more than seven days complicated monitoring and participant attendance.

Another relevant study compares five types of negotiation simulations to identify those that produced the best results. [Taylor \(2013\)](#) analyzes traditional Model United Nations (MUN) scenarios in which participants were enrolled in a credit-bearing course; simulations in which participants were not enrolled in a course; hybrid simulations; negotiation simulations based on real (but non-United Nations) topics; and simulations involving fictitious topics and actors. [Taylor \(2013, 135\)](#) concludes that, although each design is different, all provide an opportunity for profound learning, which is what makes them valuable. The biggest difference among the five types of simulations, [Taylor \(2013, 143\)](#) finds, is the role of the person who implements the simulation; when the organizer exerted greater control and structure, there was a greater opportunity to learn.

Another interesting example also provides conclusions based on the observations of the facilitating team. [Siegel and Young \(2009\)](#) describe two short negotiation simulations involving terrorist groups during a hostage crisis. The objective of these exercises was for students to gain a better understanding through hands-on practice of the theoretical concepts regarding their subject. The simulation included participation by media. Once again, however, the theoretical practical benefits claimed by the authors spring from a deep but nonsystematized analysis of their observations.

There are cases in which multiple evaluation or measurement instruments have been used in these types of simulations. For example, [Schnurr, De Santo, and Green \(2014, 401–412\)](#) write about a course on international environmental negotiations taught for several years at Dalhousie University in Halifax, Canada. The course used a simulation on the Convention on Biological Diversity. Using two questionnaires with both qualitative and quantitative questions, they authors sought to assess three aspects of student perceptions of the effectiveness of the simulation. First, were students able, in the end, to understand the complexity of negotiating the issues? Second, did the simulation increase their interest in the subject; and third did they develop additional negotiation skills? Schnurr, De Santo, and Green concluded that the students effectively understood the complexity of international negotiations (specifically on environmental issues). However, students also reported that their interest in international environmental issues declined, as did their negotiation skills. The students' greatest learning was that they obtained a realistic view of what it means to negotiate. Further, the frustration students experienced in the process prompted profound questions about how to change the rules of the game ([Schnurr, De Santo, and Green 2014, 412](#)).

Another type of evaluation used in the application of negotiation simulations can be found in [Giovanello, Kirk, and Kromer \(2013\)](#). This study uses the data collected in an introductory course on international relations, which included a simulation of a Model United Nations session, to assess student perceptions through

pre- and post-simulation. The analysis found that the students were more excited about having participated in the Model United Nations than they had indicated in the presimulation surveys. Similarly, comparing the pre- and post-simulation surveys showed that the questionnaires post-simulation showed there were fewer students disinterested in the Model United Nations than in the questionnaires pre-simulation and the questionnaires post-simulation also showed there were more students who wanted to maintain the Model United Nations in subsequent semesters than the questionnaires pre-simulation (Giovanello, Kirk, and Kromer 2013, 198).

Because of the nature of the simulations we considered researching, our literature review sought to explore published studies about simulations that used technological tools. Although we were not able to locate a great deal of material in this regard, we consider relevant a study presented by Sterman et al. (2014), which is important both for the technological aspect of the simulation discussed and for the combination of methods that were used to evaluate the exercise. Sterman et al. (2014) discuss the results of a simulation about climate issues performed virtually and in person. The participants played common negotiator roles, both individually and in groups, and they were required to consider their national interests when negotiating a global agreement to mitigate climate change. Unlike traditional negotiations, the participants' proposals were entered into a digital platform called C-ROADS, which provided immediate feedback on the possible consequences of their proposals (Sterman et al. 2014, 4). The participants were given a questionnaire in which they were asked to rate the importance of the experience from 1 to 5. The questionnaire was applied before and after the simulation. Other students submitted written comments about their experience. In addition, a focus group was conducted. Finally, a survey of 12 questions was administered to some of the simulation participants before and after participation. The results were largely positive and reflected a greater understanding of the issue, a general feeling that the simulation had been realistic, a greater awareness of what is involved in negotiations and how complicated they can be, and a considerable appreciation of practical exercises compared to lectures or theoretical classes only (Sterman et al. 2014, 24). The authors reported that students achieved a broad awareness of the climate change problem.

Despite finding all these benefits and valuable quantitative instruments to evaluate the simulations, our literature review did not identify any combination of methodological tools that included the use of qualitative in-depth interviews along with questionnaires or surveys, an analysis of essays or reports, and a detailed analysis of documents produced by students during negotiations. Similarly, except for some isolated texts, our literature review identified a considerable gap in the research regarding simulations carried out in Latin America and specifically in Mexico, where Model United Nations are very popular.

In this sense, Ángel and Cano Vasquez (2011, 4) document the importance of using state-of-the-art technology platforms to enable collaborative projects among students from Colombia, Spain, and Mexico. However, there is no evidence that these platforms or technologies are being used for simulations or negotiation models. Viveros et al. (2013, 1–3) do study the use of simulation exercises with Latin American students, but not in terms of negotiation models. Instead, they consider information management and decision-making when faced with problematic situations requiring solutions. Finally, Márquez Duarte (2017) explores the effectiveness of Model United Nations among Mexican students. In this work, the author evaluates how Model United Nations simulations used in Baja California, Mexico, positively affected youth participation in specific areas.

In summary, after our review of a wide range of texts on the use of various types of simulations and negotiation models as educational tools in international

relations and other areas, we determined that it was worthwhile to conduct the study presented here. This particular study is on a series of simulations conducted with Mexican students on global issues. Our research used a combination of mainly qualitative methodological tools to collect and analyze data. With all these elements, this paper seeks to contribute to the body of literature on this subject.

The Negotiation Simulation

This study consists of research on five negotiation simulations executed with different student groups during different semesters. Three of these models were simulations of peace conferences for the Syrian Civil War that began in 2011. The other two simulations simulated the 2015 United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP21) and the 2016 Conference of the Parties to the Convention on Biodiversity (COP13) that took place in Cancun, Mexico, that same year, a few weeks after one of our simulations.

The five simulations consisted of exercises carried out with students who were between the fourth and ninth semesters of the international relations degree at a private university in Mexico City. The simulations started with a prenegotiation phase that lasted three to four weeks in which the students played assigned roles. Students held preconference or presummit meetings and conversations in university cafes, gardens, and hallways, and in their houses. Some of them had to negotiate the agenda of the topics for the conference. Other participants were required to negotiate their actors' participation and react to the responses of other participants who were reluctant to have their assigned actor included in the summit or conference. Most students used these preconference weeks to have meetings (some public and some private) to further their different interests.

Throughout this phase and during the conference, all students opened and used Twitter accounts in their actor roles and used the *Brightspace* platform to make public announcements or upload relevant documents. All Twitter accounts clearly indicated that it was a university simulation. The students were required to follow one another, and they could also follow any other account they wanted. The professor and his team also participated through Twitter (as the host delegation from Mexico or the UN General Secretariat, as the case may be) to elicit different reactions from students, sometimes using other fictional Twitter handles for WikiLeaks, Anonymous, ISIS, and Donald Trump. All this enabled the students to issue public communications, take positions, dialogue, criticize, and even engage in long conversations and discussions for several weeks before their conference.

The simulations included the participation of both state and nonstate actors, peaceful or violent as the case may be. For example, simulations on the peace conference for Syria included groups such as secular militias, Islamic militias, Kurds, other countries involved, United Nations mediation commissions, and others such as the UN Refugee Agency. The simulations of COP21 and COP13 included corporations and various nongovernmental organizations. These actors had to negotiate their intervention in their conference, either as participating actors, as observers with a voice but without a vote, or in some other way.

Finally, during the entire initial phase of the negotiations, the organizing team shared real news reports to which the students were required to react. For example, when we were a few weeks away from a Syrian peace conference simulation, the United States launched missile strikes against the Syrian government's army in the real world because of the alleged use of chemical weapons. The students had to react to this news through Twitter and adapt their negotiation strategies to reflect the actual attack.

The five multilateral conferences in question took place over three days at a site outside of Mexico City. All of the conferences began with a gala dinner attended by the students who dressed as their respective actors and began to assume their

roles. The official sessions began on the second day of the summit and ended on the third day at 12:00 pm, after which an evaluation of the entire simulation was conducted. During all these phases, both the professor and the Mexico Research Center for Peace (CIPMEX) team took careful notes and monitored each student's participation.

Methodology

Our research involved the following qualitative assessment measures. First, we conducted thirty in-depth interviews with students months and sometimes years after their simulations. Second, we analyzed 118 reports written by the students a few days after completion of the exercise. Third, we performed a detailed text analysis of the documents issued by students during the simulations including an analysis of a sample of student tweets. Finally, we used a nonqualitative instrument consisting of a 12-question survey conducted before and after the exercise with one of the simulation groups to contrast it with the results of the other tools.

Participants and Sampling Strategy

There were 118 student participants in the five simulations. Twenty-seven students were in the first simulation, 23 in the second, 25 in the third, 25 in the fourth, and 18 took part in the fifth. Of the total, 30 in-depth interviews were conducted, six for each simulation. There were 22 interviews of women and eight interviews of men. This is consistent with the gender representation of students in the university degree program where this course is taught, and it is also consistent with the gender representation in the simulations studied. Once gender was considered, the six students interviewed from each simulation were chosen randomly. Additionally, all the reports submitted by the 118 students were analyzed. However, for the first simulation, we only had extracts from those reports because at that time we did not have this research project in mind and only kept parts of the reports. The extracts were consolidated in a single document. We did have complete reports submitted for the other four simulations. Regarding other documentation, we conducted a detailed text analysis of 17 documents, which was the 100 percent of documents issued by the five groups. Five of these documents were extremely long because they included samples of hundreds of tweets issued during the simulation in question, as well as detailed descriptions of each of the formal and informal meetings held during the entire preconference negotiation phase. The procedures for contacting and recruiting participants and for conducting this research adhered to the ethical standards and ethics committee of the university that offered the course that was the subject of our research. Each research participant signed an informed consent document, and information protection was in compliance with Mexican law regarding information security and privacy. We do not reveal here any information that could identify the participants or their university.

Data Collection and Methodological Triangulation

The first source of information for this research were the 118 reports written by the students. These consisted of five-page reports in which the students described their experience and their overall and specific negotiation techniques learned, and provide feedback on the exercise regarding deficiencies or potential improvements. These reports were course assignments graded by the professor. The research team supplemented the reports with in-depth interviews with a representative sample of 30 participants. A semistructured interview protocol was used in which the interviewer varied the questions or explored them in depth as certain themes emerged. These interviews were conducted by six different researchers who are all

coauthors of this paper. To control for potential biases and to ensure that students were comfortable in expressing negative views about the simulations, no interviews were conducted by the course professor who directed this research. Similarly, to determine the extent to which the topics identified in the interviews and reports could be verified using objective tools, we conducted an in-depth analysis of the documents submitted by the students throughout their negotiations period (three to four weeks) and of their Twitter participation. Finally, we used an additional instrument, a pre- and post-simulation survey. We administered this pre- and post-simulation survey only with the last group studied, but it enabled the verification of some of the findings from the interviews, student reports, and documents. Collectively, the use of these tools provided a variety of options that enabled us to compare, contrast, and evaluate the validity of the results presented in this paper.

Data Analysis

For data analysis, we used the qualitative *NVivo* software, which was fed with preexisting categories taken from the literature review and the conceptual framework. We also used categories that emerged during the analysis. All interviews were transcribed verbatim. Phrases or fragments of the participants' narrative were selected from the interviews and reports, and these fragments were encoded into preexisting or emerging categories. *NVivo* allows the researcher to include these fragments in more than one category, which occurred frequently during our analysis. Documents and memoranda produced during the research were also analyzed with *NVivo*. Some of the topics reached an early saturation point, while others received few mentions. Both the preexisting and emerging categories were divided into four areas: (A) Course: didactic issues/student and course characteristics; (B) Skills or tools acquired during the simulation; (C) General factors valued by the students and acquired knowledge; and (D) Deficiencies/Opportunity areas.

Reliability

We tried to ensure the reliability of this research with the following strategies: First, the interviews and analyses were conducted by six different people. We often held meetings to reveal and contain potential biases. Second, we conducted contrast tests between the different elements of this research. For example, we contrasted the interview results of each group against the others, the reports' results of each group against the others, the interviews against the reports, and all of the above against the results of the questionnaire answered by one-fifth of the whole sample. We conducted contrast tests between the three Syria simulations against the COP simulations and between female against male participants. In all cases, repetition of the most frequent patterns is very similar, with very slight variations. Third, and finally, we contrasted those findings with our detailed analysis of the tweets and documents submitted by the students. In those comparisons, the repetition of patterns could also be verified.

Limitations and Transferability

This research is limited to the five groups studied. Therefore, the findings are not immediately generalizable to other groups of students inside or outside of Mexico. All of the students in this research were studying for an international relations degree in a private university and were therefore able to make the above described three-day trip at their own expense. In addition, it is important to note that, despite all attempts to control for potential biases, the students' professor is the same person who led the study presented here. Furthermore, this investigation only explores students' perceptions after their simulations. Consequently, it is not possible to fully

Table 1. The ten most frequently mentioned occurrences

<i>Categories</i>	<i>Number of Mentions</i>	<i>Percentage of Participants who Mention at Least Once</i>
Awareness of the complexity of negotiations	510	100
Better understanding of dynamics of negotiations	468	99.2
Global awareness	411	91.6
Able to represent my actor well	394	97.5
Mention of a tactic or negotiation tactics	319	83.2
Good experience	316	89
Helped with personal or professional issues	302	80.7
Group worked well together	240	74.8
Valued role playing	237	78.9
Improved my research	220	83.2

attribute any of the findings of this qualitative research directly to the students' experiences in the simulations. That said, the highly consistent patterns detected, and the highly reliable results obtained from the group comparisons and from the comparisons of the interview narratives with student reports or documents issued, all indicate that it is possible to hypothesize that similar results could be obtained if conditions are replicated to implement equivalent or similar simulations to those in this study.

Results

As we said in the introduction, the investigation searched for student perceptions of the benefits of the simulations for their negotiation skills, for their perceptions of how well they assimilated theoretical course content on international negotiations and negotiated issues, and for their perceptions of understanding of the complexity of international negotiations. We also searched for the effect these simulations had on student level of interest in and enthusiasm for the negotiation topics and their own research skills, their reports of how the simulations disadvantaged or put them at risk, the themes most mentioned in student conversations and memories, and any contrasts between student perceptions and the researchers' observations and analyses.

Most Frequently Mentioned Benefits

The benefits most frequently mentioned by the participants were as follows. “*Awareness of the complexity of negotiations/realistic view of the problem*” received 510 mentions or 4.6 percent of total mentions, with 100 percent of the participants mentioning it at least once. “*Better understanding of the dynamics of negotiations*” received 468 mentions from 99 percent of the participants, “*Awareness of global issues/actors*” garnered 411 mentions from 92 percent of the participants, and “*Able to represent my role or actor well*” mentioned 394 times by 97.5 percent of the participants. These subjects appeared with very similar frequency during the interviews and in the 118 reports analyzed from the five groups studied. Table 1 presents a general overview of the ten most mentioned categories.

What these data basically tell us is that, on one hand, the students felt that they became aware of the complexities of multilateral international negotiations. That is, it was common for the participants to comment that they never imagined how difficult it is to make so many parties agree on such complex issues when viewing them from a distance or from theory learned in books and classrooms. The students

valued having a better understanding of the negotiation dynamics and even the dynamics of conflicts ($f = 162$, 50 percent of the participants mentioned it at least once). Similarly, participating in a simulation that they considered sufficiently realistic enabled them to become aware of the conflicts and global actors in ways that are very different from traditional educational methodologies.

Examples of this that are typical of the interview and report extracts are as follows:

- By approaching the problem in an experiential way, by putting ourselves in the shoes of those who truly seek an agreement, we can really understand how difficult it is to arrive at a solution, especially when each negotiator not only has interests that conflict with others but also has a different culture, language, and character.
- I realized that they are more complicated than I really thought. I've always wanted to work at the United Nations and I saw it as ... I knew that negotiating and when they convened in the General Assembly or in the Security Council sessions, they were complicated issues. But to see it in person now and to really try to moderate, and be a neutral party—it did not turn out badly. I just realized that it is a more complicated process and a process that involves much more than what one usually sees.
- You think that you will arrive and say: "Ah, win-win, it's easy." But no, not really... There are people who are going to tell you: "I do not want you to win, because we are enemies." So when you apply it in real life, it's not easy. So yes; before, I thought that negotiations were much simpler and that it was not much more than to arrive peacefully, reach an agreement, make an offer and say "Ah, I accept," and maybe how to lower your negotiation demands a bit. But in person, it's very different. That is, after the model, I did see that it was completely different.
- I understood it better. It was a subject that I had studied because it was part of our academic curriculum. Obviously, it was a very hot topic on the international agenda, but it was a very complicated topic to understand. Getting into my role made me understand the picture, or rather the overall picture a little better, because you can't insert yourself any more into how it happens to the US. You need to understand it in its entirety, and not only did I understand it better, but it did make me more sensitive to the disturbing situation they are living in Syria and that, to truly achieve peace is much more complicated than a two day model.
- It was an extremely enriching negotiation exercise. It helped us to better understand the position of each of the actors involved in the conflict. It facilitated the understanding of the participation of nonstate actors that intervene in the negotiation. Without these kinds of actors, the negotiations are incomplete; you cannot cater to the interests of some. The Syrian conflict is too complex, an endless series of clashes, obstacles, speeches, egos and dissenters. Our conference had a lot of ideas, perspectives, creativity and intensity.
- It was very funny to see how everyone took their role so seriously, from their clothing to their ways of thinking. Really, we all got too involved to be able to represent our characters appropriately. I never thought that a peace conference would be so tiring because everyone is just sitting around and arguing. But it is a very intense intellectual exhaustion that you are not aware of until you are living it. The truth—it was an exercise that left me thinking about many things that I had never before imagined.

To provide more detail on the results obtained, below we explore each of the four major topics of our various categories in the following pages.

Table 2. Most frequently repeated categories in topic A

<i>Categories</i>	<i>Number of Mentions</i>	<i>Percentage of Participants who Mention at Least Once</i>
Mention of some negotiation tactic or tactics	319	82.5
Mention of creativity exercises	177	67.5
Positive comments about the course	141	54.2
Positive mention of theory classes	61	29.2

Table 3. Most frequently repeated categories in topic B

<i>Categories</i>	<i>Number of Mentions</i>	<i>Percentage of Participants who Mention at Least Once</i>
Contributed to personal or professional skills	302	80
Contributed to research skills	220	82.5
Improved negotiation skills	206	69.2
Gained more information about the subject	186	69.2
Contributed to my education	168	64.5
Contributed to emotional skills	158	52.5

Course: Didactic Issues/Student and Course Assimilation

In this item, the most mentioned topic in the interviews and the students' reports was the negotiation tactics that they learned during the course and that they used during the simulation. Additionally, the students indicated that the creativity exercises practiced during the course were highly valuable for their performance during the simulation. More than half of the students included at least one positive mention of their international negotiation course, and 29 percent made some positive mention of their theory classes. See Table 2.

Skills or Tools Acquired During the Simulation

The students emphasized that the simulation helped them develop personal and professional skills that go beyond negotiating (for example, public speaking, representing a role while working in a certain environment, or resolving personal conflicts). They also highlighted other elements in addition to negotiating skill improvement, such as the development of research skills or skills to contain and control their emotions. See Table 3.

Here are two typical student comments:

- On the other hand, and on a personal level, I am somewhat impulsive and also a little like someone who always wants to be right (laughs), and so what we worked on taught me to restrain those two aspects of my personality.
- It also helped me ... I'm very shy of speaking in public, and it taught me to speak and approach people with whom I don't normally speak... I don't know, on a personal level it helped me a lot to meet more people in my degree program and make friends.

General Factors Valued by the Students and Acquired Knowledge

As already noted, this topic contains some of the items most mentioned in the interviews and reports such as acquiring a greater awareness of the complexity of

Table 4. Most frequently repeated categories in topic C

<i>Categories</i>	<i>Number of Mentions</i>	<i>Percentage of Participants who Mention at Least Once</i>
Awareness of complexity of negotiations	510	99.2
Better understanding of dynamics of negotiations	468	98.3
Global awareness	411	90.8
Able to represent my actor well	394	96.7
Good experience	316	88.3
Group worked well together	240	74.2
Valued role playing	237	78.3
Produced group unity	216	73.3
Valued the use of social media as a tool	207	78.3
Model was realistic	206	73.3

Table 5. Most frequently repeated categories in topic D

<i>Categories</i>	<i>Number of Mentions</i>	<i>Percentage of Participants who Mention at Least Once</i>
Representing my actor was difficult for me	155	57.5
The exercise tired me	130	54.2
The exercise caused me doubts, skepticism, or discouragement	120	48.3
It was difficult to reach agreements	111	44.2
The exercise confused me	100	45.0
Not everyone participated equally	98	28.3
There was too much work	89	42.5
The model was not realistic	89	29.2
Negative comment on the model	80	25.0
I did not have an active role	73	25.0

multilateral negotiations as well as a better understanding of their dynamics. In addition, it is worth noting that 97 percent of the students mentioned at least once that they could correctly represent their role. Eight of ten students valued the role playing as an educational strategy, and seven of ten considered the simulation to be sufficiently true to reality.

Regarding group issues, although this research studied five different groups, 75 percent of the students felt that their groups worked well, and 73 percent of them considered the exercise to have produced a cohesive or united group. Table 4 below shows the most frequently repeated categories in this topic.

Deficiencies/Areas of Opportunity

This category was explored in particular detail by the team's interviewers. The interview protocol contained several questions on this, and when these issues arose the interviewer sought to expand on them as much as possible. The reason is that because the reports were course assignments, we thought it was more likely that any perceived deficiencies in the simulations would surface more frequently during interviews conducted by someone other than the professor, when the student was no longer taking the course and did not have the burden of a grade on his or her shoulders. The results show that, despite several issues raised about this category, they were not as frequently mentioned, and the percentage of students who mentioned them at least once was generally lower than in other categories. Even so, it is

important to note that more than half of the students mentioned at least once that at some point in the simulation, it was difficult for them to represent their role, and 54 percent of students indicated that the exercise was tiring or burdensome. Interestingly, almost half of the students said that this exercise caused doubts, skepticism, or discouragement. We can say that at some point in the exercise and upon understanding the complexity of international negotiations, many students ended up with little hope in obtaining positive results from the exercise. This is a result that should be highlighted. Contributing to this attitude was the fact that 44 percent of the students indicated difficulty in reaching agreements. Furthermore, 40 percent of students felt that the exercise imposed an excessive workload, and 29 percent mentioned at least once that all or part of the simulation was unrealistic. Twenty-five percent of the students gave at least one negative comment or mentioned an opportunity for improving the simulation. The same percentage felt that the actor they represented did not have a relevant or active role in the negotiations. Table 5 (above) shows the most frequently mentioned categories in this topic.

The following are two illustrative comments for this topic:

- So, the fact that it is more complex makes me feel worse. Because I feel that the solution ... I do not know if it is necessarily further out of reach, but it is more complicated. That is, it's not just two plus two equals four, you know?
- It's that I think it is very, very tiring and demanding to be sitting at the same table all the time listening to people's speeches ... most of the speeches do not matter to you, and they are slow and boring. But you still have to be sitting there taking notes. So, I feel that it is a slow process in which you have to give sufficient time to each part. For example, when an agreement is ready to be finalized but someone does not agree with certain point, then you have to renegotiate everything just so that person agrees. I don't know—the whole process is exhausting.

Other Results and Miscellaneous Topics

Despite the frustration expressed by a significant number of students, there were 125 comments from 54 percent of the students that the simulation generated enthusiasm and energy in them as international relations students. Sixty-five percent of the students indicated that this type of exercise positively contributes to their education, while 60 percent of students felt that the simulation helped them think creatively or differently. One comment from the reports summarized it as follows: "It was very, very, very complicated to reach an agreement, but I realized that it was possible."

Half of the participants in this research valued the implementation of a practical simulation, as opposed to just studying theoretical information on the topics addressed. Half of the students also felt that the simulation had improved their ability to resolve conflicts. Five of ten students made at least one positive reference to the gala dinner that was held prior to the formal activities and indicated that compelling themselves to play a role in an environment such as a dinner helped improve their role-playing during the negotiations. Sixty two percent highly valued the fact that the simulation was carried out on a trip, outside Mexico City. Among the subjects with the fewest comments was that only 7 percent of students mentioned at least once that they considered that they failed to perform better or use more effective negotiation strategies. Additionally, only 6 percent said that the subject matter of the simulation did not interest them, and only 5 percent felt that their group lacked unity.

It is notable that 44 percent of the students (120) mentioned at least once the importance of the professor's role as a facilitator of this type of exercise, a result that should be considered when replicating this simulation.

Pre- and Post-Simulation Questionnaires for the Fifth Group

As explained above, we applied a questionnaire to the fifth group before starting the prenegotiation phase and again after the completion of the simulation to compare results. The questionnaire contained several questions seeking to detect changes in students' perceptions before and after the exercise. The students were asked to rate from 1 to 10 issues such as their knowledge about the Syrian conflict, about the nonstate actors in the conflict, about their understanding of the mechanisms for resolving that conflict, about the potential for resolving that conflict, and if their country, Mexico, could potentially contribute to the resolution of that conflict. We even asked about the students' personal motivations for dedicating part of their personal or professional lives to negotiation or conflict resolution.

Perceptions about their knowledge of the conflict, about the nonstate actors, and about existing mechanisms for conflict resolution increased from a range of 5–6 to a range of 8–9. When the students were asked before the simulation exercise to rate from 1 to 10 the potential for resolving the Syrian war, the group average was 3.5. After the simulation, this average rose to 7.5. Before the simulation, the students' perception of Mexico's potential for contributing to the resolution of this distant conflict was 4.7 on average. After the simulation, that average increased to 8.1. Lastly, before the simulation, students rated their personal motivation for dedicating part of their professional lives to negotiations at an average of 8.6. After the simulation, that average rose to 9.5.

Document Analysis and the Use of Digital Tools

Summarized here are our observations regarding the analysis of documents submitted by the students in all the phases of the simulations, their tweets during the weeks that their Twitter accounts were active, and the posts and announcements that they uploaded to the *Brightspace* platform.

The documents and tweets reflected the considerable time dedicated to the exercise by a significant number of the students. This included a great number of tweets (many released outside of university hours, even late at night), meeting minutes or memos, publication of agreements prior to the summit, position letters, and several others. Similarly, most of the documents contained elements demonstrating the amount of research that went into their preparation. In the vast majority of cases, these were not documents prepared hurriedly or lacking detail, but instead the documents reflected the students' interest in a thorough understanding of the positions of their actors. They drafted agreements, minutes, and memos based on data and information that were properly researched.

As suggested by the results of our interviews and report analysis, the writing and preparation effort reflected in the documents, the use of symbols representing the different actors, photographs and language, as well as the Twitter conversations, all seem to indicate that most of the students sought to represent their roles as realistically as possible. By doing so, they would achieve or at least try to achieve a simulation that would be true to real life.

An integrated analysis of all the documents at our disposal indicates that the students knew how to be creative in reaching agreements, whenever possible. However, at the same time, they sought to set realistic goals and commitments. The balance that was found in each of the five groups studied is noteworthy. The agreements never strayed beyond the bounds of the plausible. The following are illustrative extracts from the documents, tweets, and other written evidence from the databases of the five simulations studied:

- Universal Agreement on Climate Change. The Universal Agreement on Climate Change is valid for everyone, but diverse in its application. In

recognition of the many immediate and lasting benefits of global action on the climate at a national level, the global agreement is not punitive, but rather favorable and facilitating in nature. This Universal Agreement is a multilateral, binding and definitive agreement for the year 2020. The UN Climate Conference in Queretaro aims to push the world along a determined path towards a sustainable and low carbon future. This implies having an integrated development approach that considers social, economic and environmental factors, and the capacity to build on the opportunities brought by this new paradigm of sustainable development. The foundation of the agreement is the principle of “Trust but Verify” and implementation of the principles of equity and common but differentiated responsibilities, in order to produce a significant impact. The following clauses are presented below...

- @JAPON_COPBIOQRO (Japan) Achieving the Aichi goals is essential for protecting biodiversity #COP13 #PathToCOP13 #Japan #Biodiversity
- @REPI_COPBIOQRO (Special Rapporteur on the rights of indigenous peoples) We recognize the efforts of @Monsanto_COPQRO; and hope to achieve a compromise with the NGO @PI_COPBIOQRO
- @Turquia_CPSQRO (Republic of Turkey) Member of terrorist groups should be brought to justice, including those within the Turkish parliament. We are willing to sit down with all concerned parties to resolve the conflict that has displaced 11 million people.
- #PressRelease (Attached document with their position on these issues)

The students also conversed and negotiated using WhatsApp. These chats were shared with us as part of the evaluation. Below is an example:

- Student A: OK, OK then what are your interests? In other words, how can I help you?
- Student B: Let me talk to my colleague and we'll let you know today ☺
- Student A: Perfect
- Student B: We all know, we want you to push more for Assad to leave, he has to leave NOW, NOW, NOW and we want you to finance the weapons that you want us to use to attack Iran
- Student A: Ha, ha, bring us a globe and the little pistols from our presentation
- Student B: Ah, well but nobody has to know that you...

Many of the documents were provided as paper copies and were analyzed directly from the physical materials that we kept. These included signed agreements and memoranda among others.

Discussion

First, as a didactic educational tool, this research yields evidence that contributes to the existing body of literature and indicates that it is possible to produce broadly scoped negotiation exercises that complement theoretical lessons and bibliography reading to foster valuable student involvement in the subjects they study. This will be covered below. Beyond that, however, this research sought to determine the extent to which incorporating elements beyond those traditionally used in simulations can produce effective results in students' perceptions.

The use of an extensive period of negotiations prior to a “summit” or “conference,” guided by appropriate advice from facilitators or experts, allowed the students to get into their diverse roles gradually. The addition of other tools such as incorporating nonstate actors who participate in real life negotiations or the use

of communication tools such as Twitter contributed to the feeling of realism that was felt by most of the participants in this research.

In addition to the above, if the facilitators inject additional elements that provide greater simulation plausibility—such as the bombardment of authentic news stories shared in real time in each of the five simulations in this study—then the result will be an exercise that most participants view as highly complex, with all the related advantages and disadvantages. Moreover, the students appeared to have felt that they were experiencing something close to real negotiations, which led them to put the tools they learned into practice and to be creative in developing alternatives. However, most of the comments we obtained referred to the complexity of multilateral international negotiations that caused frustration or discouragement for some students. This is consistent with the literature on the subject (e.g., [Schnurr, De Santo, and Green 2014](#)).

However, this research yielded results that should be further analyzed. A significant number of students felt frustrated. Nevertheless, most of them felt greater enthusiasm and energy from this exercise and had a good experience. The vast majority felt that the simulation contributed to their education and provided them with tools that could be used in other areas besides negotiations.

The foregoing may be largely due to the fact that, while in the process of understanding the complexity of this type of negotiation, they were also understanding the dynamics of the conflict (162 mentions) and how these negotiations work (468 mentions). In other words, it is true that multilateral negotiations are highly complex, and it is a fact that this complexity could cause students to become discouraged with this type of work or lose hope in the possibility of resolving the world's conflicts. However, it is also the case that by facilitating an environment of dialogue in which students can try out their creativity (99 mentions) and their teamwork (58 mentions)—without losing a consistently high level of truth to reality (206 mentions)—students are likely to demonstrate the enthusiasm and energy (125 mentions) needed to resolve complex negotiations. In that sense, it is worth recalling two elements of the instrument applied to the fifth group that increased significantly after completing the simulation: their level of hope in the possibility of actually resolving the Syrian conflict and, notably, the possibility that Mexico could contribute positively in that resolution. Lastly, for at least the students in that group, the desire to devote part of their personal or professional lives to negotiation or conflict resolution also increased after simulation completion. However, to achieve these results, it is clearly necessary to combine realistic elements with adequate preparation in terms of tools that exercise and develop creative thinking.

Finally, the factors identified in this discussion are not merely the individual products of interviews, reports, or separate surveys. Rather, they are products of combining and contrasting all those instruments. By integrating them as a whole, we can conclude that the net result of this type of exercise is positive. Admittedly, these are long, onerous, and sometimes fatiguing exercises that are not simple to implement. However, the benefits as described by the research participants outweigh the negative factors.

Connecting These Findings with Literature on International Negotiations

As mentioned above, our findings can be easily linked to the literature on the theory and pedagogy of international negotiations. For instance, [Raiffa \(1982, 144\)](#) explains that both distributive and integrative negotiations normally work, not because they are ethical but because they tend to be rational. Interestingly, according to Raiffa, the decision-making structure in negotiations seems to work in a laboratory as well as in the real world of diplomacy or daily life ([1982, 224](#)). This validates the use of simulations both in pedagogy and as experimental laboratories. However, when there are more than two negotiators, and more than one issue

to negotiate, the negotiation tends to become enormously complex (Raiffa 1982, 130). Our analysis appears to confirm that the above factors were operating in each of the five simulations we conducted. After having been part of simulations that included multiple actors and multiple negotiation issues, *Awareness of the Complexity of Negotiations* was the most frequently mentioned category by our participants. That said, it is equally important to note that seven out of ten participants mentioned that the exercise had improved their negotiation skills, thanks to the implementation of creative strategies based on a better understanding of how the dynamics of negotiations work (468 mentions). Those elements helped them explore ideas about how to produce integrative negotiation scenarios so that all parties could win in the process.

Furthermore, Raiffa (1982, 19) highlights the importance of mediation to unlock conflicts, a topic also studied by others (e.g., Wilkenfeld et al. 2003, 279–280; Quinn et al. 2006, 445). Classic mediation literature identifies three basic styles of mediation: facilitation, formulation, and manipulation, depending on the degree of intervention that mediators exert during negotiations (Quinn et al. 2006, 444–445). Likewise, Wilkenfeld et al. (2003, 279–280) question whether mediation affects the dynamics and results of negotiations in times of crisis and whether the impact of mediation varies depending on its style. To answer their questions, the authors carried out experiments with students, in addition to using other tools. One might think it impossible to draw clear conclusions about such issues from the study of a student population or that just using students does not offer the full picture of how human behavior works. However, Wilkenfeld and his colleagues claim that, if the discoveries are taken as theories rather than empirical findings, the analysis of groups of students makes sense as an additional tool within various research methods (Wilkenfeld et al. 2003, 290–292).

The results of our study are eloquent in those terms. First, in every case, several styles of mediation were implemented, not merely one. In all five simulations, a United Nations mediating commission either played a facilitating role or acted as a formulator. To this, we added other types of mediation roles along with other types of interests. In some cases, powers such as the United States, Russia, or the European Union played the role; in others, mediation occurred internally as in the case of the student representing Riyad Hijab (a Syrian politician who defected from Assad's government) who was in charge of reconciling different positions of the Syrian opposition, the various Syrian militias, and other nonstate actors. Implementing this kind of situation as a laboratory yielded interesting results, such as the students' perception of the number of realistic components within their simulations that contributed to their understanding of how difficult it is to negotiate under such circumstances. At the same time, by understanding how conflicts and negotiations work, the students perceived they could develop or implement negotiation tactics (319 mentions) and said that their simulations fostered creative thinking (59 percent of participants mentioned that category) especially in those who played a mediation role. In other words, as we have said, the research presented here contributes to the literature that argues that, given certain conditions, simulations may be used to better understand human behavior in negotiations under complex circumstances. Like Raiffa (1982), Wilkenfeld (2004) explains that, by experimenting, researchers see things that they would not otherwise see, and by doing so, it is possible to improve international relations (Wilkenfeld 2004, 429–431).

Examining a different aspect, Druckman and Wagner (2016, 11) highlight the relevance of the prenegotiation phase for beginning to implement justice in a negotiation process, which improves the chances of producing stable agreements. This seems to be corroborated in the five simulations studied in this research. Nine out of ten students perceived the preconference phase (three to four weeks) as crucial to advancing the agenda and ultimately reaching agreements. Albin and Druckman (2016, 111) study the topic of justice, specifically in environmental negotiations,

and conclude that justice mechanisms do, in fact, matter in this type of international conferences, especially in highly complex ones. The treatment of justice influences the direction of the process and has an impact on the final result. The qualitative analysis of our two COP simulations seem to support those assertions. The findings of the interviews, reports, and documents reflect the importance that students assigned to the mechanisms of justice that were discussed before and during the environmental conferences. Several interviews relate how the entire negotiation process was about to fail because of the lack of agreements precisely on justice issues and the role that the mediation of the UN and its Special Rapporteurships had to play to ensure that parties could reach concrete agreements on such matters. It is important to note that, in both environmental simulations, the students were creative enough to propose justice mechanisms that successfully led to agreement by all parties.

Furthermore, it is worthwhile to make some connections between our results and Zartman's (2015) research, explicitly regarding the particularities of negotiations in the context of the Arab Spring. Our simulations seem to replicate several aspects pointed out by the author, starting with the level of reality perceived by the students based on the number of actors that participated in the negotiations, including the rebel militias. Zartman (2015, 112) detects that in the negotiations that emerged from the Arab Spring, the actors needed to establish broad coalitions that could generate strength and consensus among them. According to Zartman (2015, 119), the negotiations carried out by actors who emerged from the Arab Spring were not comprehensive and integrative but resulted, instead, in very narrow distributive processes. That did not help to establish solid social contracts. This was apparent in our three simulations about the war in Syria and was reflected both in interviews and students' reports. In fact, only when the students representing the vastly diverse actors of the Syrian opposition were able to join forces and show creativity to achieve integrative negotiations could they get Syrian President Assad to relax his positions, and thus agreements began to flow. Zartman argues that no traditional negotiation model works for the cases of the Arab Spring. "No ideal type is an accurate portrayal of reality, and this one is no exception. Models serve as templates that help understand what works and why, when it works, and why not" (Zartman 2015, 110). This was widely considered before the implementation of our simulations and corroborated by the results of the present investigation. One in two students highly valued the inclusion of nonstate or nontraditional actors; 86 percent considered the prenegotiation phase relevant in order to replicate a realistic and fruitful scenario. All this contributed to the understanding of how complex these negotiations can be, but at the same time aided students' perception as to the possibility of developing parallel or alternative skills to deal with the problems that arise from negotiations.

Finally, our investigation offers evidence that can also be linked to the literature on the pedagogy of international relations in more than one area. One is the use of technology to teach international relations. Pleschová (2015) suggests using tools such as online discussion forums, podcasts, and other similar instruments. Our five simulations used technological tools such as the *Brightspace* platform (which includes discussion forums, among other instruments). Moreover, our simulations included the use of Twitter before and during the main conference negotiation summits. Student involvement with technological tools was found to be very intense. In fact, the enthusiasm of the students was noticeable in the tweets and posts that they issued very late several nights (which was repeated throughout the five simulations). This was also reflected in the students' perceptions; 94 percent mentioned in both their interviews and reports that they considered the use of Twitter and other digital tools to be very valuable for their exercise.

Continuing with another pedagogic aspect, Asal, Raymond, and Usherwood (2015) attempt to describe that same enthusiasm and passion among international relations students when teachers implement simulations in classrooms. The authors explain that "active learning is more valuable than passive learning" (Asal,

Raymond, and Usherwood 2015, 304) and that a simulation offers the opportunity to “live the world” of the phenomenon studied, which engages students in a special way. In the authors’ words:

If I have to pretend to be the head of the French Defense Ministry unit responsible for sub-Saharan policy, and if I have to then engage in a simulated interaction with officials from NATO, then I can get a much more nuanced understanding of the international response to Mali than I can from a lecture on the same subject (Asal, Raymond, and Usherwood 2015, 305).

This, the authors explain, is due to three basic benefits of simulations: (1) they allow students to explore substantive issues; (2) simulations help students understand the dynamics of international negotiations and institutions more clearly; and (3) simulations can also enable the creation or improvement of group identity. Our findings offer ample evidence to support those three benefits, and perhaps even more, first regarding student enthusiasm and engagement with the negotiation exercise, subjects, and actors represented, aiding in their understanding of the negotiated topics, their comprehension of the dynamics of the negotiations and the conflicts, and, above all, the development of parallel and creative thinking skills to face the complexity of negotiations. Likewise, *Group Integration* was also one of the categories most frequently mentioned by the students, in both the interviews and their reports.

In sum, the present work offers evidence from a Latin American experience that links directly to many theoretical principles and to the pedagogy of international negotiations. Below, we present some recommendations taken more specifically from the study of our five simulations.

Recommendations for Future Research and Educators

The use of simulations in education, as discussed above, is very widespread. But there has been a significant absence of systematic documentation on the use of simulations in Latin America, particularly simulations that go beyond traditional United Nations–based scenarios and those that make use of social media and other technological tools. Although this study seeks to provide some contributions in this regard, it is evident that the scope of its findings is limited to the groups studied and the specific type of simulations implemented. Therefore, and by virtue of the findings that we are sharing in this work, it is well worth expanding this type of research.

One possibility is to apply this approach to more diverse groups (students from different universities, from different cities or countries, from different socioeconomic strata), with negotiation simulations that are the same or similar to those presented here. Then, the task is to study the information that they yield and the results of the simulations. Following this is the task of conducting in-depth interviews with participants to verify whether the patterns exhibited in the current research are repeated or whether new or different topics emerge and, where appropriate, explore their potential causes. Another possibility is to conduct research similar to that presented in this paper and contrast the results in negotiation simulations with different characteristics. Another alternative would be to develop a quantitative instrument based on the results of this research to determine if the patterns detected in our research are repeated in other sites and/or in other types of simulations and to apply that instrument in much broader student samples. One last idea would be to conduct interviews or apply assessment tools with participants several years after the exercise in order to identify whether skills or lessons learned have any practical utility in their professional lives.

Similarly, there is broad educational benefit in the kind of negotiation simulations explored here. The results of our research add to a considerable body of literature that support the use of negotiation simulations. Our research in particular seems to provide positive findings for the application of the type of exercise that requires more than diplomatic or political negotiation skills and ventures into areas such as the control of emotions or the development of interpersonal skills.

However, for these exercises to work properly, active, dynamic facilitation and permanent advice is required. More than half of our students report that at some point in the simulation they had difficulty representing their roles. Similarly, more than half reported having felt tired, and one of every two students expressed feelings of frustration, disappointment, or discouragement at least once after seeing what happened in the simulation. In contrast, a large number of students said that they gradually overcame these types of feelings when they better understood the dynamics of the conflict and the negotiations. A significant number of the participants felt satisfaction when using creative strategies or parallel thinking in the design of proposals and agreements. This imposes considerable challenges on those who decide to implement this type of simulation. Care should be taken for the simulation to sustain a rhythm and for facilitators to continually advise students to stay in their roles as realistically as possible, while at the same time students should be encouraged to allow imagination, dialogue, proposal, and effective mediation to prevail. To this end, the facilitation team must take care of every detail of the simulation, from beginning to end. Otherwise, the benefits of this type of simulation can be limited or nonexistent.

At both the high school and university levels, it is worthwhile to try to go beyond traditional United Nations models and explore diversity in issues and conflicts. Many simulations are offered in the pages of *Model Diplomacy* from the Council on Foreign Relations,¹ except that most of these are oriented toward the foreign policy vision of the United States. In places such as Mexico, Latin America, and other regions, one can envision simulations adapted to a large number of local or regional issues, or to the role that our countries could or should play in global issues, from environmental issues to commercial ones, or to various conflicts, even if they seem very distant.

We suggest that topic selection be guided by relevance and timeliness to feed the simulation with real breaking news, even if these change the dynamics of the negotiations or influence processes that had already been worked on. This requires students to immerse themselves in the historical, social, political, and economic information of the simulation and become involved with and learn to manage the flood of news that they experience. Similarly, the insertion into the simulation of completely real issues that emerge from real-world negotiation processes can help develop students' capacity to respond to unforeseen and unexpected questions.

We also suggest providing students with seven to 21 days to start negotiations prior to a "summit" or "conference." This allows them to get involved with their roles and begin learning about their own actors and others with whom they will have to negotiate. In addition, considerable progress can be made in these phases, which tends to foster a positive mood before the conference or major summit. During this period, it is worthwhile to oblige students to use available technology such as social media to the best of their ability. This was one of the areas most valued by the participants in our research because these communication tools are not only frequently used by students of their age, but the students also explore different skills and communication strategies that are not always used in traditional models.

Finally, we recommend incorporating nonstate or nontraditional actors in the negotiation schemes. The personification of roles like these seems to provide parallel or alternative views in the students and at the same time offers challenges that must be addressed by mediation teams or state actors.

¹ Council on Foreign Relations, *Model Diplomacy*, accessed January 30, 2019, <https://modeldiplomacy.cfr.org/#/>.

Conclusion

Despite its limitations, this research conducted through the study of five simulations conducted in different Mexican student groups over five different semesters seems to substantiate the net positive result that can be obtained by using negotiation simulations as educational tools. We attempted to evaluate, as much as possible, a series of strategies usually not included in traditional simulation models. These strategies included the integrated use of the most current and realistic instances of multilateral negotiations possible, an initial negotiation phase lasting several weeks in which students had to respond to real-world news, the use of communication tools such as social networks, the inclusion of very active nonstate actors in the negotiations, and a gala dinner.

Through in-depth interviews and an analysis of student reports and documents and tweets used by students in the simulations, it is possible to assert that the vast majority of student perceptions, feelings, and assessments were positive. These models seemed to contribute significantly to student education and to the development of negotiation and many other skills.

The issue that emerged most frequently in this investigation concerned students' awareness of the complexity of the negotiations. Complexity can be both a risk and an opportunity. It can be a risk because many students might become discouraged and frustrated by it. Complexity is an opportunity, though, because, properly channeled, it can help students trigger parallel skills and creative thinking to solve complex problems. The role of the facilitation team in helping students with this complexity is essential. In the end, the problems of the world are in fact complex. Solving them is not at all simple. The question is how to take advantage of the educational strategies presented here to enable students to face this complexity and transform it into personal growth that, we can say with certainty, will be difficult to forget.

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